Saturday, January 27, 2024
Magh 13, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaaga Dwitiya

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 42 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN

Nepal U19 team defeated Afghanistan by one wicket on Friday to enter the Super Six round of ICC U19 Men's World Cup Cricket. Aakash Chand (centre) celebrates with his team mates after taking his fifth wicket in East London, South Africa, Friday.

PM stresses dialogue for world peace

Meeting held with high level UN disarmament team



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' meeting with the UN's Under-Secretary-General and High Representative for Disarmament Affairs, Ms. Izumi Nakamitsu, in the capital on Friday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has emphasised the importance of dialogue for world peace. He said this when meeting with the high-level delegation from the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs.

With the delegation led by United Nations' Under-Secretary-General and High Representative for Disarmament Affairs Izumi Nakamitsu, Prime Minister Prachanda called Nepal's peace process exemplary and stressed that dialogue was the only way to achieve global peace.

He said, "Many parts of the world are going through sensitive times right now. Crises like the Russia-Ukraine war and the Israel-Hamas conflict have created challenges for peace. But we insist on the need to find solutions through dialogue."

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'Nation building responsibility now on new generation'

Minister Sharma opens national technology festival

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the time has come for the new generation to engage in the nation-building tasks.

While inaugurating the LOCUS-2024, the 20th National Technological Festival, which began at Pulchowk Engineering Campus on Friday, Minister Sharma said that it was time for the new generation to show their motivation and commitment that they were here to build the country instead of criticising the shortcomings of the older generation.

Minister Sharma urged the youths to appreciate the contribution of the freedom fighters to the political transformation in the nation.

Minister Sharma added, "Now the new generation should take the responsibility of building the country while respecting the contribution made by the old generation."

Moreover, in today's era of information technology, the technical manpower should lead the work of building the country, she said, adding that the new generation should dream of a prosperous Nepal.

Given the complaints of the new generation that there has been too much political interference in the educational sector, she informed that for the first time in the history of Tribhuvan University, the leadership selection process has started through an open competition.

"The government is trying to carry out transformational plans in every sector by adopting the main agenda of good governance, social justice and prosperity, and it needs your support and cooperation," said Minister Sharma.

In the age of information technology, we have no option but to adapt to the latest technological developments, she said. "The country can move forward only by adopting technology, and digital transformation is the prerequisite of digital transformation," Minister Sharma added.

She clarified that there should be no delay in making a plan in the latest fields such as robotics, AI, IoT, Blockchain, and using all these technologies for the benefit of the country and its citizens. She said that the government believes that Nepal should have its satellite.

Pointing out that there is a need for study and research in communication and information technology that suits the country's soil, she said that to provide support in this regard, Nepal Telecommunication Authority and the Institute of Engineering, Pulchowk had agreed to establish an information technology excellence centre and the government's goal was to establish such excellence centres in all seven provinces.

Renewable energy bill to be tabled within a month

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26



Minister of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet has said that the bill related to renewable energy will be tabled in the federal parliament within a month.

While addressing the International Day of Clean Energy and the 27th anniversary of the Alternative Energy Promotion Centre (AEPC) in Kathmandu on Friday, Minister Basnet said that the government was going to table the 'Renewable Energy and Energy Efficiency Bill' to the Parliament to address the changing conditions and demands of the times in the field of alternative energy and renewable energy.

He said that about 98 per cent of households have access to electricity across the country and made it clear that work to provide electricity to all households within the next one and a half years has made progress.

He said that the government was making a planned and meaningful effort to increase electricity consumption and make it available for other purposes as electricity is currently available only for lighting purposes.

As hydropower is also a renewable energy, he said that the government has given high priority to carbon trading, stressing that more benefits should be taken from it.

Stating that the recently concluded COP28 in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) also aimed to double the use and production of renewable energy by the year 2030, he said that the government would move ahead according to the same policy internally.

Making it clear that the government has always addressed the legitimate demands of the private sector, he said that the government was also working together with organisations or businessmen involved in the field of renewable energy.

Dr. Prabhu Budhathoki, a member of the National Planning Commission, said that with the aim of overall development of the energy sector, the government has made necessary legal and structural arrangements and implemented them.

Secretary of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Gopal Prasad Sigdel said that Nepal was very vulnerable in terms of the impact of climate change and to reduce the impact of climate change, it was necessary to go into energy mix and create a suitable policy environment for it and hydroelectric projects, which are the main source of energy, as well as solar energy.

He also expressed his commitment that the Renewable Energy and Energy Efficiency Bill, which is currently being drafted and is in the process, will be moved forward as soon as possible.

Executive Director of Alternative Energy Promotion Centre Nawa Raj Dhakal said that the AEPC has been playing a significant role in providing access to electricity to the people even in the remote areas as per the goal of the government.

On the occasion, Dhakal presented an annual work progress of the centre for the last fiscal year as well as the current situation and future roadmap of Nepal in renewable energy and energy efficiency. Various organisations working in the field of renewable energy and employees who have served for 20 years in APEC were honoured on the occasion of the anniversary.

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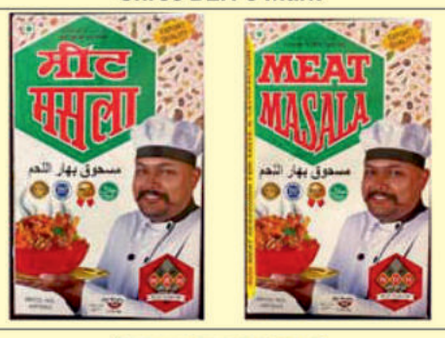
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Dated this 23rd January, 2023

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Govt under pressure due to low revenue collection: FM Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the government is now under pressure because of its inability to collect the revenue as per the target set by the government for the current fiscal year.

Addressing a programme organised by the Department of Customs on the occasion of the 72nd International Customs Day on Friday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the government was still under pressure from the point of view of revenue mobilisation. He said that even though the revenue mobilisation has increased over the months, it has not been as per the target set for the current fiscal year.

He said, "Now, we are under a lot of pressure in terms of revenue collection. There has been some increase in revenue. But we have not been able to meet the target that we had set. One of the reasons for not meeting the target is the change in the revenue structure, he said.

He said that the import of electric vehicles increased significantly, resulting in poor customs revenue. He said that as the customs duty imposed on electric vehicles is lower than on petroleum-based vehicles, the customs revenue has been less by about Rs. 35 billion.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat also emphasised the need to strengthen digitisation for the improvement of customs administration. He stressed the need for everyone's initiative to build a modern customs administration using various technologies, international standards and good practices.

"The goal of revenue should be achieved by strengthening the overall customs administration and businesses should be brought under the tax regime based on the true assessment. It is necessary to focus on creating a modern customs administration using new technology," said Minister Mahat.



PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat addressing 72nd International Customs Day programme on Friday in Kathmandu.

Finance Secretary Dr. Krishnahari Pushkar said that the Ministry had prioritised investment in improving the customs administration. He said that the Department was making improvements in cooperation with the private sector to facilitate trade.

Dr. Ram Prasad Ghimire, Revenue Secretary at the Ministry of Finance, said that the customs administration was not only a means of collecting revenue but it could play an important role in making internal and foreign trade dignified and orderly.

Director General of the Department of Customs Shovakanta Paudel said that professional and administrative honesty was necessary in the customs sector. He said that the Department of Customs was ready to harmonise the customs process with international best practices, improve the customs infrastructure and adopt paperless, faceless and contactless working systems.

President of Nepal Chamber of Commerce Rajendra Malla stressed the need for strengthening the customs administration to provide government services promptly.

While being committed to the reform and modernisation of the customs administration, it is necessary to bring it into the scope of strict action to control illegal imports, said President of Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) Rajesh Kumar Agrawal.

REVENUE COLLECTION OF SAGARMATHA NATIONAL PARK UP BY OVER 10%

RSS
Salleri (Solukhumbu), Jan 26

Revenue collection has increased by more than 10 per cent at Sagarmatha National Park, Namche, in Solukhumbu. The revenue collection has gone up by 10 .54 per cent in the first six months of the current fiscal year 2080/81 BS as compared to corresponding period of previous fiscal year 2079/80 BS.

As per the data on revenue collection shared by the Park, it had collected Rs 62.32 million revenue from Saun (July 17 to August 17, 2023) to Push (December 17, 2023 to January 14, 2024) of the previous fiscal year. Similarly, Rs 69.67 million revenue was collected during the corresponding period of the current fiscal year, said Information Officer of the Park, Manoj Kumar Mandal.

He shared that Rs 656,000 revenue was collected in the month of Saun, Rs 3.395 million in Bhadau (August 18 to September 17, 2023), Rs 21.054 million in Asoj (September 18 to October 17, 2023), Rs 31.227 million in Kartik (October 18 to November 16, 2023), Rs 10.143 million in Mangsir (November 17 to December 16, 2023) and Rs 3.21 million in Push (December 17, 2023 to January 14, 2024) of the current fiscal year. Also the conservation officer of the Park, Madal added the highest Rs 66.67 million revenue on tourism heading, Rs 4.083 million revenue on forest fodder sales heading and Rs 2.5 million from penalty.

MUGLIN-POKHARA ROAD: BLACKTOPPING USING ASPHALT TECHNOLOGY STARTS IN WEST SECTION

RSS
Damauli (Tanahun), Jan 26

Blacktopping has started in the west section of Tanahun under the Muglin-Pokhara road expansion project. The Muglin-Pokhara road project (west section) has begun blacktopping the road from Shuklagandaki municipality-2, Haledi of the district under the Jamune-Pokhara.

Road Section's engineer and Information Officer Narayan Poudel shared that 420-meter one-way blacktopping was done first day on Thursday. According to him, the target is to blacktop the one-way five kilometer section by coming March 13.

He further shared that blacktopping will also be carried out from Jamune of Myagde rural municipality and Belchautara of Shuklagandaki municipality from today onward. "Now the work will be expedited and the blacktopping work will continue. Necessary human resource and equipment are ready".

In the first phase, only one-way blacktopping will be done and two-way will be taken ahead once the one-way work goes ahead, he said. The road project has taken forward the blacktopping using asphalt technology. Under the western section, the work from Jamun to Pokhara had started from 29 August 2021 after signing an agreement on 14 May 2021.

China cuts bank reserve requirements to boost property lending

AP
Bangkok, Jan.26

China's central bank said Wednesday it will cut amount of reserves it holds for banks as part of a slew of measures to support the slowing economy. The announcement by the governor of the People's Bank of China prompted a surge in share prices, with Hong Kong's benchmark jumping 3.6%.

Chinese stock markets have languished in recent months as investors pulled money out, discouraged by a faltering recovery from the shocks of the COVID-19 pandemic.

A sell-off earlier in the week was followed by unconfirmed reports that the government planned to get state-owned investment companies to funnel offshore funds into the markets to help staunch the losses. The central bank's moves appear to be part of a concerted effort to stabilize the markets and instill greater confidence in the outlook for the world's second-largest economy.

Central bank Gov. Pan Gongsheng told reporters in Beijing that the deposit reserve requirement would be cut by 0.5 percentage points as of Feb. 5. Pan said that would inject about 1 trillion yuan ($141 billion) into the economy. As of December, the reserve requirement ratio was 7.4%.

Unlike bank reserves — the cash banks must keep on hand to cover unexpected demand — these reserves are held by the central bank and used mainly as a monetary policy tool. Such changes are usually conveyed in a written notice by the central bank, not at a news conference.

Pan said the central bank also plans to issue a policy soon on lending to property developers to help support the industry. China's economy is recovering, he said, allowing ample room for policy maneuvers. "At present, our country's financial risks are generally controllable, the overall operations of financial institutions are sound, and financial markets are operating smoothly," the government website China.com cited Pan as saying.

The economy expanded at a 5.2% annual pace in the October-December quarter, enabling the government to attain its target of about 5% annual growth for 2023. But the recovery remains uneven, and most forecasts say the economy will grow more slowly in 2024. Chinese leaders have been talking up the economy in an all-out effort to counter such expectations.

Mark Williams of Capital Economics said the latest moves would "provide only a small boost for China's economy." "Meaningful improvements in household or corporate borrowing would require substantial rate cuts or a significant change in economic sentiment. Neither seems likely in near future," he said in a commentary.

The slow pace of the recovery after China dropped stringent anti-virus precautions in late 2022 has added to gloom over a crisis in the once-booming property market as dozens of developers defaulted on loans after the government cracked down on excessive borrowing a few years ago.

That has left many Chinese families who had invested their life savings in unbuilt homes in limbo, unsure if the developers would deliver those apartments. There have been some signs of improvement: Last week, the government resumed its reporting on the rate of unemployment among young people, which stood at a record 21.3% in June. According to a revised methodology, the latest youth unemployment rate was 15%. Overall unemployment stood at 5.1%.

Many youths also were left without work after the government cracked down on technology companies, which tended to hire younger workers. More recently, moves to impose more controls on online gaming spurred massive sell-offs of game company shares, leading the authorities to apparently backpedal on that plan.

The Federal Reserve and other major central banks have been raising interest rates and finding other ways to raise the cost of borrowing to help stem inflation, which peaked at 9.1% in mid-2022 in the United States. Central banks are now easing their monetary policies as price pressures abate.

In China, regulators are grappling with the opposite problem, a risk that weak demand will cause prices to spiral lower, discouraging investment and hobbling growth. The moves by the central bank this week will ease credit and pump money into the economy to try to spur businesses and consumers to start spending more.

Street traders announce phase-wise movement against KMC

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The Joint Self-employed Street Traders Struggle Committee has announced a phase-wise movement against the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC), putting forth a seven-point charter of demands.

Organizing a press conference here today, the Committee declared that it will wage a protest movement from January 29 to February 11 under various phases. Accordingly, the Committee will hand over a memorandum to the KMC on January 29, will organize a sit-in and picketing along with public demonstration at the KMC office on January 30, will submit a memorandum to the Kathmandu District Administration on January 31, said Maya Gurung, the President of Nepal Self-employed Trade Workers Association.

According to her, they will hand over memorandum to the Ministry of Home Affairs on February 1, to the Prime Minister's Office on February 2, to the CPN (Unified Socialist) party on February 4, to the CPN (Maoist Centre) on February 5, to the Nepali Congress on February 6 and to the CPN (UML) on February 7.

Likewise, the Struggle Committee will hold a protest demonstration with wider people's participation, clanging plates with spoons and also picket the KMC office on February 11, said Kumar Sapkota, President of Nepal Independent Street Trade Workers Organisation.

He said a seven-point demand has been submitted to KMC with the announcement of the programmes of protest.Returning the goods of traders seized by the KMC in different periods, making arrangement of goods in cheap price for the citizens by running 'fair price market', in all wards of KMC, allowing the entrepreneurs to run their business in the existing places by determining appropriate time until alternative arrangements are made, are the demands of the struggle committee.

Similarly, the struggle committee demanded to initiate activities related to labour management by establishing labour desk at KMC immediately and to immediately form a high powered management taskforce under coordination of mayor and deputy-mayor comprising stakeholders including trade unions representatives associated with the struggle committee, said Chairperson of National Self-Employed Traders Association, Leela Bahadur Dahal.

Gurung shared that they would announce additional programme of agitation if the bodies concerned did not pay any interest to address demands of traders, adding they have wanted a long-term solution by holding discussion.Similarly, Sapkota demanded that the KMC should bring self-employed street traders under the ambit of tax after managing the street business.

Although municipal police had expressed commitment to return the seized goods of traders, the traders have been returning empty-handed, said Chairperson Dahal.

French farmers block roads against low wages

AP
Paris, Jan.26

French farmers staged protests Wednesday across the country and in Brussels against low wages and what they consider to be excessive regulation, mounting costs and other problems.

Roadblocks were spreading in many French regions, one day after a farmer and her daughter died due to a traffic collision at a protest barricade. Farmers have also been turning road signs upside down to protest what they argue are nonsensical agricultural policies.

Some were planning to protest in Brussels, home to EU headquarters, where French farmers' union Rural Coordination called for a demonstration against the "ever-increasing constraints of European regulations and ever-lower incomes."

The protests are the first major challenge for newly appointed Prime Minister Gabriel Attal, who took office two weeks ago, and his government. Attal met with farmers' unions representatives on Tuesday.

Following the meeting, Agriculture Minister Marc Fesneau promised to make new proposals to respond to the crisis by the end of the week, including regarding food prices and simplifying regulations.

Co-operative branding turmeric after sugarcane and ginger

RSS
Galkot (Baglung), Jan 26

A cooperative here has initiated multi-dimensional productions amidst widespread criticism that the cooperatives are not performing as per their objectives.

The Baglung-based Simrik Agriculture and Livestock Commercial Cooperative Organization that has been producing sugarcane and ginger since past six years has initiated branding and marketing turmeric from this year onwards.

The cooperative has been cultivating sugarcane by renting 10 ropanis of barren land in two areas of Kathekhola rural municipality-2, Bhimapokhara and two ropanis at Kundule in Baglung municipality-4 for the last three years. Similarly, it has been cultivating ginger in two ropanis of land in Titaure. The cooperative has been selling 20 quintals of sugarcane annually.

This year, the cooperative has sold turmeric worth Rs 100,000 and distributed other seeds to the members, said Jagannath Sapkota, treasurer of the cooperative and a leading farmer of Kundule. "It has been two years since the cooperative started turmeric farming. We have started selling turmeric from this year," he said, adding that the seeds distributed should be returned to the cooperative in the following year.

The cooperative has been distributing ginger and turmeric seeds to most of the shareholders. The cooperative has been producing sugarcane, turmeric and ginger in three places, it was informed.

Chairperson of the Cooperative Chudamani Upadhya said although the cooperative could not produce big volume it has focused on mobilizing members for small scale agro production, including turmeric.



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

Simkot Airport has remained deserted for the past four days because of flight disturbances owing to thick fog in Nepalgunj Airport in the morning and wind in Simkot in the afternoon.



PHOTO: TRN

Dr. Lyarkaal Lama, vice-chair of Lumbini Development Trust, inaugurating lighting of 100,000 Lights on Thursday with plans for daily Illumination going forward.

Lawsuit filed against two crypto traders

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The Department of Revenue Investigation (DRI) has filed a case against two persons for dealing in the dematerialised currency USDT Coin (Tether), also known as Cryptocurrency.

Nawaraj Adhikari of the Investigation Officer for the Department who investigated the transactions of USDT Coin said that a case was filed in the Lalitpur District Court on Thursday after completing the investigation.

The case has been filed against the defendants Shubham Kumar Yadav and Rohan Chaudhary.

According to the Department, a case was registered against them after a thorough investigation lasting for five months. The investigation revealed that defendant Shubham Kumar Yadav used the Binance app and Ko Pitupi channels to deal in dematerialised currency.

In addition, the investigation revealed that Yadav used his friend Rohan Chaudhary's account to keep and withdraw the transaction amount.

Investigating officer Adhikari said that they filed a charge sheet demanding punishment under Section 17 of the Foreign Exchange Regulation Act, 2019.

He said that from them, the Department had sought Rs. 140 million amount to be deposited in the government's coffer.

Nawa Raj Dhungana, Director General of the DRI, has stated that the transaction of immaterial currency was being investigated in detail.

Ex-policeman held in Kolkata 16 years after letting a detainee flee

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

A former policeman accused of helping a drug dealer escape from police custody was arrested 16 years after the incident.

The Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office has arrested Birbal Raya Yadav, the former constable, accused of helping Ashraf Alam, who was in the custody of the Hanumandhoka Police Office 16 years ago. Former constable Yadav who was absconding for 16 years was arrested and made public on Friday.

Speaking at a press conference organised by the Office this morning, Spokesperson for Police SP Rabindra Regmi said that Yadav had asked Ashraf Rs. 10 million to free him.

Yadav was arrested from Kolkata, India and brought to Kathmandu via Kakarbhitta border point on Thursday.

During the press conference Yadav said, "After 16 years, police (sir) have caught and brought me here, now whoever committed a mistake, the Nepal Police will not let him go." He believed that he had made a smart escape, but Nepal police caught him 16 years after his escape.

According to Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Somendra Singh Rathore, Ashraf a resident of Raxaul, India, who was in the custody of the then Metropolitan Police Range, Kathmandu, at Hanumandhoka, escaped from the custody in the support of Yadav in 2007. Then Ashraf was 39 years old.



PHOTO: TRN

Absconding former policeman Birbal Raya Yadav.

Yadav, a permanent resident of Pathrabudharam-3, Rautahat, used to work in the detention cell of Kathmandu Police. He had made a fake receipt and took Alam out of the detention cell saying that he was called by the field officer (inspector). After that, it was revealed from the investigation that Yadav also fled to India with Ashraf.

According to the police, it was found that Yadav purchased and started running two taxis in Kolkata, India, with the amount he had received from Alam.

Now he has nine taxis, India's Aadhaar card, voter card and driving license, police said. He was living in Kolkata, India, with his wife.

Panchakot preparing for Maha Yagya

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Baglung, Jan. 26

Preparations for the Bramandhiya Mahayagya at Panchakot, a renowned religious site in Baglung, are going on with zeal and zest.

To transform Panchakot in Baglung Municipality-6 into a prominent religious tourist destination, the Bramandhiya Maha Yagya is scheduled to be held from February 19 to March 4, 2024, as per the decision of Muktinath Pithadhishwar Swami Kamalanayanacharya.

Sudarshan Prapannacharya, the spokesperson for the Maha Yagya, said that the aim of the event includes elevating the stature of Muktikshetra and Shaligram to the global stage, inspiring the Vedic Sanatan Hindu society to safeguard and preserve Nepal's water resources, and reviving moral values to foster a progressive and ethical Nepali society.

He mentioned that the construction of necessary infrastructure and publicity for the Maha Yagya has been intensified. Currently, activities such as maintenance, painting, tent construction and the building of Habankunda (holy fire-making place) on the premises of religious shrines in Panchakot are going on.

The funds collected from the Maha Yagya will be utilised to complete the construction of the Bishwashanti Kalash in Panchakot, along with the construction of the religious shrines in Panchakot Dham.

Rudra Bahadur KC, the ward chairman of Baglung Municipality-6 and vice-chairman of the Sarbasiddhi Dham Panchakot Greater Development Committee, said that they aim to develop Panchakot as a tourist and religious destination by constructing a 108-feet-tall Kalash.

"Arrangements have been made to install 5,555 kg bells in Panchakot. Through the Maha Yagya, we aim to collect funds and transform Panchakot into a significant religious tourist destination, attracting millions of religious tourists and devotees from Nepal and India," said KC.



PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA\TRN

A glimpse Panchakot, a renowned religious site in Baglung.

> The Bramandhiya Maha Yagya is scheduled to be held from February 19 to March 4, 2024, as per the decision of Muktinath Pithadhishwar Swami Kamalanayanacharya.

"We aim to develop Panchakot as the gateway to the prominent religious site Muktinath. The pitcher being constructed here will have thirteen floors, resembling that of a house, and a Detailed Project Report (DPR) has been prepared for this purpose. Despite its external appearance, there will be 16 rooms inside the Kalash. The rooms will be utilised for conducting religious activities," KC informed.

It is estimated that the investment in infrastructure construction amounts to approximately Rs. 4 billion. The funds generated from Maha Yagya and the contribution from the Government of Nepal would be utilised to develop Panchakot.

Karna Bahadur KC, Coordinator of the Panchakot Construction Committee, informed that significant structures are presently under construction in Panchakot. These include the temple of Gandaki Mata, Hanuman's statue 'Sis Mahal', Hanuman Batika, Gandaki Gopal Gaushala, and other small temples.

Infrastructure development work in Panchakot, covering an area of over 200 ropanis of land, has been done through financial aid collected by the Akhanda Jyoti Baba Swami Sriji Charitable Trust, the founder of Kamalanyanacharya.

MONTH-LONG MADHAV NARAYAN FESTIVAL BEGINS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The month-long fasting of Madhav Narayan has formally begun with devotees gathering on the banks of the Sali Nadi at Sankhu and Hanuman Ghat of Bhaktapur.

Devotees observe the religious fast of Madhav Narayan performing various rituals on the bank of the Sali Nadi.

The first day of fasting started on Thursday taking a holy dip in the Sali Nadi early in the morning.

The annual fasting of Madhav Narayan and recitation of Swasthani starts from Paush Shukla Purnima (Full moon day) to Magh Shukla Purnima.

During the fasting month, devotees gather on the bank of Sali Nadi around 5.00 am every morning to take a holy bath.

Male devotees offer Sastanga Namaskar to the Madhav Narayan temple from a distance of about 50 meters every day after taking the holy bath, said Mijendra Kaji Shrestha, President of the Shree Madhav Narayan Swasthani Fasting and Sali Nadi Management Committee.

About 218 devotees have registered their names for fasting. However, the number of devotees can rise in the coming days, as one can join the fasting four days after the full moon day, he added.

The devotees that take a month-long fast eat one meal a day- in the evening following a strict diet comprising rice, carrots, green beans, ghee etc.

On the day of Ekadasi, they usually eat bananas, yam, sugarcane and oranges.

Men and women of all ages observe this fasting wishing for a prosperous life, perpetual luck and happiness. The Sali Nadi has a special significance during Swasthani Bratakhata as a sacred healing and wish-fulfilling site.

Resunga's park comes into operation

BY TILACHAN PANDEY
Tamghas, Jan. 26

A park has been constructed in Gadjura of Resunga at a cost of nearly Rs. 60 million. After a dispute erupted between the construction company and Resunga Municipality was resolved, the park was handed over to the municipality for its operation.

An agreement was signed between Resunga Municipality and the construction company New Leaza JV to complete the construction of the park by March 2023. The construction work was completed ahead of the deadline, but the park was not handed over to the municipality as dues were not paid to the construction company in time.

Mahendra Ghimire, the construction businessman, reported that after receiving the remaining payment of Rs. 22.9 million a few days ago, they handed over the park to the municipality.

Mayor Khildwaj Panthi said that after the park was handed over to the construction company, the municipality brought the park into operation.

According to the municipality, the entry fee for foreigners, Nepali nationals, students and senior citizens is Rs. 100, Rs. 40 and Rs. 20 respectively. The municipality has also assigned three employees for the protection, maintenance, and operation of the park.

However, following the park's opening, a rivalry has emerged between former Mayor Dilliraj Bhusal and sitting Mayor Panthi. Supporters of both mayors are engaged in disputes over ownership of the park through social media.

Even though the construction company completed the work ahead of the schedule, they had to wait a long time to receive the agreed payment, because of the dispute between the sitting mayor and the former mayor.

Bhusal, the former mayor and current member of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly, asserted that the park's establishment was successful solely due to his initiatives and actions.

He stressed that he was the mastermind behind the park's development, having initiated the contract after resolving issues caused by the Forest Office. Claiming success in securing the tender only after multiple proceedings with the Federal Ministry.

Bagmati govt endorses agro self-reliance scheme

BY RAMMANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Jan. 26

A community-based One Ward One Agricultural Product Programme will be launched in Bagmati Province.

A cabinet meeting of the Bagmati Province government approved the procedure for implementing the One Ward, One Agricultural Product Programme following the endorsement of the Action Plan.

The Bagmati Province government has accorded top priority to agriculture in its policies, programmes and budget for the current fiscal year to make the province self-reliant in agricultural production.





Bagmati Province Minister of Internal Affairs and Law, Ganga Narayan Shrestha, informed that during the meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Thursday, the procedure regarding the implementation of the 'One Ward One Agricultural Production Programme' was approved.

The meeting decided to approve the Chiuri (Indian butter trees) and bat Conservation Programme Operation Guideline, 2080 (2024) for the upliftment of the Chepang community in districts mainly inhabited by Chepangs in the province.

Shrestha, who is also the spokesperson for the provincial government, informed that the meeting approved the Bagmati Provincial Senior Citizen Policy, 2080 (2024), and the Educational Scholarship Guide, 2080 (2024).

Additionally, the meeting decided to request the Government of Nepal to provide a building for the office of the Communication Registrar.

A decision has been made to request the Federal Government to temporarily release the office space of the Postal Services Office and get back it when needed by the Federal Government.

Notice of Sealed Quotation for Fuel Procurement at Narita, Japan

Date of Publication: - 27 Jan, 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation, a fully government owned national flag carrier of Nepal, hereby invites Sealed quotation(s) from interested and qualified fuel suppliers/re-sellers for Into Plane Delivery of Aviation Fuel (ATF) at NRT/RJAA for refueling Nepal Airlines Flights.

AIRPORT (ICAO CODE)	ESTIMATED UPLIFTMENT (TONS/MILLION USG)	CONTRACT PERIOD
Narita International Airport-NRT(RJAA)	111856 TONS/3.901282 MILLION USG	01 Mar 2024 to 28 Feb 2026

The detailed information about this Sealed Quotation Invitation can be obtained by visiting Nepal Airlines Corporation Official Website under Notices section.
https://www.nepalairlines.com.np/notices
Your SEALED QUOTATION(S) must reach by 1600 Hrs Nepal Standard Time on 10th Feb 2024 in a sealed envelope and delivered through courier at the following address.

Nepal Airlines

DIRECTOR
OPERATIONS DEPARTMENT, HEAD OFFICE
NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
4TH FLOOR, NAC BUILDING
NEW ROAD GATE, KANTIPATH, KATHMANDU, NEPAL
TEL: +977-1-4222268; FAX: +977-1-1-4225348
E-MAIL: dir.od@nac.com.np

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

You cannot find peace by avoiding life.
-- Virginia Woolf

Honing Rationality Of Interest Articulation

Dev Raj Dahal



Interest articulation is one the vital constants of democratic politics. It is a strategy of mature people to express their needs, rights, interests and issues to political parties, public sphere and polity. Transmission of messages by Nepali leaders to people to allure them, however, is marked by the tumult of shouting, speaking and waving leaving no room for reason, conscious reflection and conversation. The rationality of interest articulation brings about the condition of peoples' living, disposition of power and distribution of intelligence in the social structure, system of control and leadership ability to hear the rhythm of public utterances. It shapes the idioms of political life by setting a balance between inputs and outputs of the polity.

Nepali leaders' highly rhetorical style of rousing the emotion of people to reach out to them may be electric, offensive, dull and dry, sober or flip to the leery of deceit and sleaze. Politics turns empty if it does not serve public good and leaves people to freeze in the reality of power without policy once elections are over. The captivating power of articulation is well defined by its driving effects. It awakens the sober hearts and minds of silent masses to move to consequential activities and bridges the chasm that divides the leadership from people on public and national interests, sapping national will in crisis times. The tone of articulation can be lawful, impassioned, pushy or radical where demands are contestable or just non-negotiable as it aspires for structural reforms even regime change.

Fawning circle

No Nepali leader can rise up to the majestic height of full political scale without ably articulating the claim, voice and visibility of people through media and spawn a ripple of hope that vaults opportunity and keeps authority effortlessly floating. The dose of eulogy of political bosses as statesmen by their fawning circle despite their failure to elevate themselves to leadership and think in generational terms only blows up their ego like Dr Frog leading to a perilous path. The statesman is driven by realistic vision, conscience, moral streak and positive outcome. Youths' only dream to go to far-off places for improving their lot eludes this rank.

The alchemy of interest articulation is an art of enthusing in Nepalis a spirit of inquiry, critical sense of evaluation of leadership and the common voice for collective action in setting the track of politics. It is not just a sound-bite but a powerful means for Nepalis for self-reflection and cognitive expression of ideas, beliefs, purpose and practices in the public sphere for attention and engagement. It is also about how Nepali leaders match with the values treasured by people for a symbol of bigger social change. The modern value of leadership is based on trust, persuasion and team spirit for bridge building, not coercion, pressure and control that divides the people and possible leaders by walls. Their styles, values and preference matter for unproblematic democratic progress. Nepali leaders' ability to stand up for constitutional ideals and perk up the lots of people who look down on them enables them to keep alive the flame of freedom, justice and peace.

Conversion of divergent interests of Nepalis into their common rights provides a shared background for civic life and shores up the eloquence of wits and democratic citizenship, an ability to see themselves not simply citizens of the nation, but also rational human beings bound to citizens of other nations by ties of mutual recognition, common concern, common good and tolerance to plurality. The tendency of Nepali leaders to shelve issues rather than solve them one by one has created an overload of grievances in the system unable to carry. Civil society and media are helping people to read this and help them to actualise, animate, assert, identify and articulate their concerns and blow off their steam of activism. The degree of social modernisation in Nepal is uneven, sluggish and slothful making the deficits of articulating agencies.

In highly developed parts it is often caught up in the powerful spell of either leaders' innocent adulation or dire criticism, not restrained by civic decency. So does the pattern of political education and interest aggregation eased by rights-based constitution, development and democracy. It has spawned the explosion of many articulating associations, federations, unions, networks, societies and social movements which are awakening the consciousness of people but afflicted by a lack of control over anything. Only keeping the proportionality of rights with duties can enable leaders and people to give up part of their interests for public good, craft a sane order of reformist type and control the pull of populist politics. Otherwise, the disjuncture between politics and law will consume the integrity and virtue of the other or even collude in mutually serving ways.

Nepali leaders must have the capacity to know, interpret and alter the condition of Nepalis lives as per the ideal vision of an impersonal polity and titillate a stimulate fit to govern national affairs. The traditional method of political articulation was through communal frame with diffused interests each simmering with its own style of informal face-to-face contact and communication. The group basis of politics is now flattened by the rise of individualism and resolution of tension between human rights and democracy in favour of the former. The collective form of life built by democratic solidarity too is replaced by network-based society with the decline of ideological politics.

> The alchemy of interest articulation is an art of enthusing in Nepalis a spirit of inquiry, critical sense of evaluation of leadership and the common voice for collective action in setting the track of politics.

The monopoly of interest expression through official medium has now spread into various mediums of associational groups — hierarchical ones like political parties' chain of command and control, utilitarian one regulated by free collective bargaining in trade unions and business association, shared sentiments of functional federations governed by the spirit of cooperatives, irrigation, local bodies and professional groups, horizontal associations of a myriad of civil society founded on education and advocacy, projectised ones indulged in social engineering, voluntary groups based on charity and cultural groups such as Guthis, the custodian of culture. The bubble up of these uncoordinated agencies has helped the political life of Nepalis transparent, articulate and reflective self-expression of the cycle of hope struggling to lift up their dreams for optimal fit.

The continuous exposure of Nepalis to independent media, public debate and political activities has made them attentive, active, fluent, democratic and demands articulating. This marks the spur of an interface between the traditional and modern means of interest expression but also a disclosure of a widening gap in the substance of promises of leaders and their eroding creditworthiness. The language of politics in Nepal is marked by exaggerated sense of leaders' personality, not their functional and specialised efficiency required of their competitive qualities, alternative visions and policies which often collides with resource constraints and problem solution thus turning politics combustible. Accumulation of social, economic and political vices and woes indicate that the essential standards of politics in Nepal is down, sullied and depreciated habitually inept to grasp the core of the constitution and fairer aspect of the surface level of life.

Effective and credible interest articulation by Nepali leaders can remove the tradeoffs between their promises, mindfulness and their capacity to overcome self-estrangement. Nepali polity can keep its dynamics by improving the degree of feedback between leaders and people at the grassroots level who appeal to different concerns and issues — personal and political. Ironically, leaders are attuned to addressing the crowd in an abstract manner with generalised appeal delinked from individuals' concern, their emotional intelligence and feeling. Too much party-mindedness of Nepali leaders has caused a biased expression of interests and erosion of culture of impartiality in fulfilling the public expectations for the bulge of opportunity so that even the poor have a stake in democracy. Deficient aggregation and representation of people's interest means losing credibility and political support to them.

Critical democratic sense

The time has come for them to choose between the emergent revival of cadres' critical democratic sense and safeguarding the unity and discipline of the party by inclusive and broad-based aggregation and articulation of public interests through inquiring, listening, consultation and deliberation beyond the weary rehearsal of ego. In a sense, the legitimacy of the political process rests on the style of articulation. It is highly rewarding for Nepalis to know the state of democracy and stabilise political life by bridging the growing split between the secularity of politics and its lack of value-based acculturation.

The worthy job of political parties in interest articulation lies in expressing the needs, interests, demands and claims of people to the decision making of Nepali polity. Countless institutions exist to assume this role at various scales. Interest groups are located both inside the polity such as civil service organisations and outside it. Managing them within the bounds of the constitution is crucial so that articulation of popular demands is not overshadowed by the din of special interest groups. In each political change Nepalis yearn for higher practical ends than those advertised by their leaders full of political jargons against the enormous array of the nation's ills whose solutions are required to offer democratic and peace dividends and enable people to act together in nation-building.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Can 'No Parking' Zones Make Business Sense?

AASHISH MISHRA

Local businesses and storefronts are vital to any urban economy. They bring communities together, provide daily essentials more easily and cheaply and make neighbourhoods vibrant. And there is no denying that vehicle accessibility and convenient parking are crucial factors that influence the number of customers these establishments receive. That is why declaring commercial streets as no parking zones sounds counterintuitive. This week, the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) took such a step and prohibited street parking in New Road, much to the anger and fright of the shop owners there. But, speaking purely from a business point of view, this could be a blessing in disguise.

Yes, parking creates convenience for potential customers, but it can also be a hassle keeping buyers away. The thought of having to find a parking space along busy streets can keep people, especially those with cars, out of certain neighbourhoods entirely. But when they become no parking zones, people will, at first, get enraged, but then, they will get used to the idea of a certain location or locality not being for vehicles. This is a difficult concept to iterate but it is about eventual acceptance. People will not stop going to New Road, they will, sooner or later, stop bringing their cars and motorcycles there.

But, even if we overlook this point, there is no denying that designating a street as a no parking zone enhances walkability. Without the clutter of parked cars and bikes, pedestrians will have more space to navigate and explore local shops. Signboards and display windows will also have a greater chance of catching people's eyes because they will not be hidden behind vehicles. A vehicle-free street becomes more inviting to pedestrians and can boost their shopping experience. There are numerous international examples to cite here. Areas with improved walkability tend to see an increase in overall economic activity. People are more likely to linger, discover new business and make impromptu purchases when they do not have to squeeze between cars to cross the street or have to view the unappealing sight of rows after rows of stopped motorcycles.

If planned and coordinated properly, the very businesses worrying about losses may be able to develop additional avenues of income in parking-free roads. Imagine cafes expanding beyond their shutters and setting up outdoor seating, street vendors having designated spots on footpaths or venues for open-air performances using the space once used for parking vehicles. Even if the local government takes an antagonistic view toward road-based commerce, as KMC currently does, it can turn street-side parking lots to extend footpaths, plant trees, build *Chautaras* and *Phalchas* or set up something like weekend farmers' markets. The point I am trying to make is that the vacant spaces can be used to foster public gatherings and when people gather, they will obviously eat and drink at local restaurants, purchase snacks and other Kirana items at local shops and wander around other stores and businesses. Additionally, such spaces will add character to neighbourhoods.

More broadly, no parking zones will promote sustainable urban transportation. Designated no parking zones can encourage the use of public transit, cycling and walking, reducing overall congestion and contributing to a healthier environment. To clarify with an example, a person coming to New Road may now choose to use a micro or a bus or, if they have one, take their bicycle. This means there will be one less polluting vehicle on the road from their home to their destination. Or, even if they do use their personal automobile, they will have to park it at the Kathmandu View Tower, which itself can now become a new commercial complex owing to the increased footfall. No parking streets have a knock-on effect across the city.

But for all or any of this to be possible, city officials must plan, communicate and collaborate. They must plan about (a) how to enable businesses to cope with the inevitable short-term losses, (b) how to prevent over-parking and congestion in areas around the streets made parking free (as is supposedly being seen in alleys and yards around New Road) and (c) how to utilise the empty spaces they will have available to them in the public interest. Authorities must communicate these ideas to the residents and business owners that will be most affected by this, and they must heed the responses they receive. The era of top-down policymaking has well and truly passed. And they must collaborate with other entities, local clubs, associations and business groups, to ensure a sustainable implementation.

No parking is not something to be afraid of. It may be an immediate inconvenience, but it can boost business in the long run. Of course, much of the onus is on the KMC.

Need To File Writ Petition Responsibly

Saroj Bhattarai



The legal system incorporates a variety of judicial and quasi-judicial bodies designed to alleviate the burden on courts and provide specialised expertise. Despite the availability of alternative remedies, there is a growing tendency to bypass these channels and directly file writ petitions. The judiciary, particularly the Supreme Court (SC), has extraordinary powers to intervene in matters of public interest or constitutional questions when necessary. However, the misuse of this power for trivial matters threatens the efficiency and credibility of the legal system. The written petition to make the work done by the ruler of the state by the law also takes action both in the form of scriptures and weapons. But for some time now, writ petitions have been filed only for the sake of intellectual luxury and cheap popularity. Increasing writ petitions in court is not a problem, but filing a writ petition for personal gain without using alternative remedies is also unfair to other parties.

Remedy

Provisions in the Article 133, Article 144 and Article 151 of the Constitution of Nepal have been made regarding the rejection of writ petitions. The rights provided in these articles are not limited rights. If the ruler and anybody governed by him/her commits an illegal act, these articles are used to keep that act as it is, to cancel such act and for other purposes as well. If there is no provision for remedy for the fundamental rights or if there is a provision but such remedy is found to be insufficient or ineffective, if there is any dispute of public rights or concern for the enforcement of such legal right, or if there is any dispute of public right or concern, or if there is any necessary order for the determination of legal or constitutional question, providing appropriate remedy, courts, especially the SC, have the extraordinary right to exercise such rights or settle disputes. Such extraordinary jurisdiction of the court is writ.

Several judicial and quasi-judicial bodies have been created to provide subject expertise and reduce the increasing burden on the courts, among other reasons. It has also been mentioned in several judgments of the SC that writs should not be used until alternative remedies are available. Yet the trend of trying to register a writ in the SC is increasing day by day ignoring the SC's judgement. Although there is a hearing in the Administrative Court regarding several disputes of employees working in the civil service of Nepal Government, Nepal Federal Parliament Service, or public institutions, writs are filed regardless of the jurisdiction.

Similarly, the Companies Act, 2063 provides that the registrar will hear the proceedings of the company registrar's office (CRO). Although the law provides that a complaint can be filed before the registrar at the CRO, a writ is filed against the order made by the CRO without submitting an application to the registrar. The remedy is sought through the process of writ even on tax assessments made by other tax assessment agencies including the Customs Office. Writ remedy is sought on the subject of assessment of tax for the purpose of remedy without going to the Revenue Tribunal.

The tendency of filing writs – by both common people and law professionals – to show themselves as famous and intellectual in front of the world is increasing. Studying the number of writs filed in the SC in the last date, it seems that there is a group of legal professionals who always stand ready to file a writ in the SC. Many wits have been filed by legal professionals on the same issue. Once the writ is registered, if an interim order is demanded in the writ, the court spends a lot of time on the writ, discussing it, informing the opponent, listening to the arguments of parties and opposition, etc. Even though the hearing of the petitions filed concerning legitimate demands and enforcement of rights takes years, that period cannot be considered as a waste of court time. But the hearing of the writ petitions filed only for the sake of intellectual luxury and cheap popularity has caused injustice to the parties of other cases as well, pushing legitimate cases deserving timely resolution to the back burner.

> To prevent the misuse of writs, legal practitioners and court administration should play an important role and prevent filing the writ for the sake of intellectual luxury.

Legal processes frequently extend over extended periods, and when a case reaches its resolution, the urgency of the presently raised matter may have diminished. Societal perspectives and priorities can change, resulting in a reduced focus on the concerns initially raised in the writ. Public attention may shift towards new challenges, overshadowing the urgency of previous issues. Delays within the legal system, whether caused by backlog or procedural complexities, can diminish the core impact of the writ, making the relief less effective. Additionally, the emergence of new issues tends to be overshadowed by persistent old ones, creating a loop where unresolved past issues overlap with present concerns. As proceedings unfold for these lingering issues, their significance often dwindles, perpetuating a cycle where the essence of each issue fades over time. This ongoing loop contributes to the accumulation of caseloads in the SC.

Responsible advocacy

The importance of judicial discretion in addressing writ petitions deserves emphasis, given the need for critical evaluation of each case's merits and the use of court time. Judicial intervention should be reserved for matters of genuine public interest or constitutional significance, not for cases driven by personal motives. Establishing a code of ethics and guidelines for responsible advocacy can help curb the misuse of writs and maintain the sanctity of the legal profession. Intellectual freedom should be balanced with a sense of responsibility. Legal professionals are urged to consider the broader implications of their actions and prioritise the pursuit of justice over personal recognition. Writ itself is a beautiful subject. Just because the number of writs increases in the court, it cannot be considered as a misuse. But its wrong use has made it ugly. To prevent the misuse of writs, legal practitioners and court administration should play an important role and prevent filing the writ for the sake of intellectual luxury.

(Bhattarai is a student at the Kathmandu school of law)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 27, 1974

Road Named After Martyr

Lalitpur, Jan, 27: The Lalitpur town panchayat has decided to name the Bhimsenthan-Balkumari road after Martyr Sukra Raj Shastri, reports RSS

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READER'S MAIL

Provide Parking Space



I am writing this to express my frustration at the lack of parking space in many government institutions in the Kathmandu Valley. The other day I had to go to the Bir hospital's newly constructed mammoth COVID building to visit my grandfather who had been admitted there as a patient.

Once I reached its gate, to my surprise, I was asked to park my vehicle elsewhere but not in the hospital premises. The guard recommended I go to the Old Bus Park to park my four-wheeler. Why is this so? Shouldn't an institution this big be able to allocate a parking space to accommodate its visitors?

How can we travel miles just to park our vehicles and come back on foot? This makes no sense at all. Denying the space to park despite having one is a pure disservice. The hospital administration must take this inconvenience seriously and work to ensure parking space to at least those coming to see their admitted relatives.

Kamal Chhetri
Ekantakuna

TAILPIECE

Two brunettes and a blonde are driving in the desert when, all of a sudden, their car breaks down.

As none of them have any motoring knowledge, they decide to walk. Each of them decides to take one thing with her.

The first brunette takes some food in case she gets hungry, the second brunette takes some water in case she gets thirsty and the blonde takes a car door.

When questioned about her choice, the blonde replies:

"Well, if I get hot, I can roll down the window!"

A husband died. A few weeks later the wife died. As she got to heaven she saw her husband. She ran up to him with tears in her eyes.

'Darling, how I've missed you!'

The husband extends his arms stopping her from embracing him and says, 'Whoa there woman, the contract was until death!'

UN court set to rule on Israel genocide allegation in Gaza

AP
Netherlands, Jan. 26

The United Nations' top court is set to rule Friday on a call for Israel to halt its military offensive in Gaza, when it issues a preliminary decision in a case accusing Israel of committing genocide in the tiny coastal enclave.

Joan E. Donoghue, president of the International Court of Justice, will read out the highly anticipated decision made by a panel of 17 judges in a case that goes to the core of one of the world's most intractable conflicts.

Friday's ruling, however, is only an interim one; it could take years for the full case brought by South Africa to be considered. Israel rejects the accusation and has asked the court to throw the charges out.

While the case winds its way through the court, South Africa has asked the judges "as a matter of extreme urgency" to impose so-called provisional measures to protect Palestinians in Gaza.

Top of the South African list is a request for the court to order Israel to "immediately suspend its military operations in and against Gaza." It is also asking for Israel to take "reasonable measures" to prevent genocide and allow access for desperately needed aid.

In a statement Thursday, Palestinian Prime Minister Mohammed Shtayyeh said he hoped the decision would "include immediate action to stop the aggression and genocide against our people in the Gaza Strip ... and a rapid flow of relief aid to save the hungry, wounded and sick from the threat of slow death that threatens them."



PHOTO: AP

A protester waving the Palestinian flag stands outside the Peace Palace, which houses the International Court of Justice, or World Court, in The Hague, Netherlands, Friday, Jan. 26, 2024.

Israeli government spokesperson Eylon Levy said Thursday that Israel expects the court to toss out the "spurious and specious charges." Israel often boycotts international tribunals and U.N. investigations, saying they are unfair and biased. But this time, it took the rare step of sending a high-level legal team — a sign of how seriously it regards the case and likely the fear that any court order to halt operations would be a major blow to the country's international standing.

An Israeli official said that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu huddled with top legal, diplomatic and security officials on Thursday in anticipation of the ruling. He said Israel is confident in its case but discussed "all scenarios." The official spoke on condition of anonymity because he was discussing confidential meetings. Israel launched its massive air and ground assault on Gaza after Hamas militants stormed through Israeli communities on Oct. 7 killing some 1,200 people, mainly civilians, and abducting another 250.

The offensive has decimated vast swaths of the territory and driven nearly 85% of its 2.3 million people from their homes.

More than 26,000 Palestinians have been killed, the Health Ministry in the Hamas-run enclave said on Friday. The ministry does not differentiate between combatants and civilians in its death toll, but has said about two-thirds of those killed were women and children.

The Israeli military claims at least 9,000 of those killed in the nearly four-month conflict are Hamas militants.

U.N. officials have expressed fears that even more people could die from disease, with at least one-quarter of the population facing starvation.

Marieke de Hoon, an associate professor of international law at the University of Amsterdam, said she thinks the court is unlikely to throw the case out Friday since the legal bar South Africa has to clear at this early stage is lower than the one that would be applied for ruling on the merits of the accusation.

"The standard ... is not, has there been genocide? But a lower standard," she said. "Is it plausible that there could have been a risk of genocide that would invoke Israel's responsibility to prevent genocide?"

Turkey's President approves Sweden's NATO membership



PHOTO: AFP

Turkey's President Recep Tayyip Erdogan during a press conference in Ankara, on January 24, 2024.

AP
Turkey, Jan. 26

Turkey published a measure approving Sweden's membership in NATO in its official gazette on Thursday, finalizing the ratification that brings the previously nonaligned country a step closer to joining the military alliance.

Hungary now remains the only NATO ally not to have ratified Sweden's accession.

Turkey's parliament endorsed Sweden's accession in a vote Tuesday.

The ruling party said the Nordic country's tougher stance on Kurdish militants was key to winning approval.

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan also has linked the ratification to Turkey's desire to buy fighter jets from the United States.

NATO-member Turkey had delayed Sweden's membership for more than a year, accusing the country of being too lenient toward groups that Ankara regards as security threats.

It sought concessions from Stockholm, including moves to counter militants.

Turkey also had been angered by a series of demonstrations by supporters of the outlawed Kurdistan Workers' Party, or PKK, in Sweden as well as Quran-burning protests that roiled Muslim countries.

Erdogan has linked ratification of Sweden's NATO membership to the U.S. Congress' approval of a Turkish request to purchase 40 new F-16 fighter jets and kits to modernize Turkey's existing fleet.

He has also urged Canada and other NATO allies to lift arms embargoes on Turkey.

U.S. administration officials have said they expect relatively quick action on the F-16 sale after the ratification.

KING CHARLES III IS ADMITTED TO HOSPITAL

AP
London, Jan. 26

King Charles III was admitted to a private London hospital Friday to undergo a "corrective procedure" for an enlarged prostate, Buckingham Place said.

The 75-year old king will be treated at the London Clinic, where the Princess of Wales is recovering after undergoing abdominal surgery. The king visited Kate at the hospital after he arrived.

"The King was this morning admitted to a London hospital for scheduled treatment," the palace said. "His Majesty would like to thank all those who have sent their good wishes over the past week."

Charles, who acceded to the throne 16 months ago, was diagnosed with the benign condition on Jan. 17 after going for a check-up because he was experiencing symptoms. He cancelled engagements and was urged to rest ahead of the procedure.

The publicity around the king's surgery is seen as an opportunity to encourage other men to have their prostates checked in line with public health advice.

The palace said the king was "delighted to learn that his diagnosis is having a positive impact on public health awareness."

French President Macron joins India's Republic Day celebrations

AP
New Delhi, Jan. 26

Thousands of people lined a ceremonial boulevard in the heart of India's capital on Friday to watch a colourful parade showcasing the country's military power and cultural heritage to mark its 75th Republic Day.

French President Emmanuel Macron attended the parade as the chief guest at the celebration of the adoption of the country's Constitution on Jan. 26, 1950, following India's independence from British colonial rule.

Indian President Draupadi Murmu escorted Macron in a ceremonial British-era horse-drawn carriage from the nearby president's palace to the viewing stand.

It was the first time the carriage has been used at the parade since it was abandoned by the government 40 years ago in favour of an automobile.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, wearing a saffron-and-yellow–coloured turban representing Hindu nationalist colours, greeted Macron at the viewing stand.

The parade was broadcast live by television networks and watched by millions of Indians across the country.

India traditionally invites foreign leaders to witness the spectacle. Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sussi was the guest of honour last year, former French President Francois Hollande in 2016 and former U.S. President Barack Obama in 2015.



PHOTO: AP

French President Emmanuel Macron, left, and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with his arm outstretched, ride an open vehicle together during a road show in Jaipur, Rajasthan, India, Thursday, Jan. 25, 2024.

Ten Southeast Asian leaders watched the parade in 2018.

Tanks, missile systems, infantry combat vehicles and medium-range surface-to-air missile systems were displayed at the parade, with hundreds of police and military personnel marching with them. Stunt performers on motorbikes, including more than 250 women, also joined.

Other participants included a camel-mounted regiment with moustachioed riders led by a shiny brass band.

Floats showcased Hindu Lord Rama, whose temple was inaugurated earlier this week, India's moon lander, its first indigenous aircraft carrier, a light combat aircraft and helicopter, and a submarine.

Macron accepted India's invitation at short notice after U.S. President Joe Biden couldn't make it, reportedly because of his State of the Union address and re-election bid.

A French 30-member band and 90-member marching group joined the parade.

A French transport aircraft and two fighter jets from the French air force joined 54 Indian air force aircraft in a fly-over past the viewing stand.

"A great honour for France. Thank you, India," Macron said on X, formerly called Twitter.

Rajpath Avenue, built by India's former British rulers, has been redeveloped as part of the celebrations of the 75th anniversary of Indian independence three years ago.

It is lined by huge lawns, canals and rows of trees and has been renamed Kartavayapath, or Boulevard of Duty.

PRISM

Firefighters rescue dog from frozen river

Massachusetts: Firefighters in Massachusetts came to the rescue of a dog that fell through the ice covering a frozen river and was hanging on by his front paws.

The Braintree Fire Department said the dog, named Rupert, went out onto the ice covering the Weymouth Fore River and fell though near the end of Edgehill Road.

Firefighters arrived to find Rupert hanging onto the ice by his front paws, but unable to climb out of the water.

Firefighters donned wetsuits and used a rope and a flotation device to reach Rupert and carry him back to shore to be reunited with his family.

Pakistan unveils world's largest bouncy castle

Pakistan: A bouncy tourist attraction in Pakistan has been named the world's largest inflatable castle by Guinness World Records.

The record-keeping organization said Jumbo Jump in Karachi officially took the record for largest inflatable (bouncy) castle when it was measured at 15,295.51 square feet.

The attraction, unveiled in November, took the record from Dubai's JumpX, which earned the title in January 2023.

Jumbo Jump, which aims to attract more tourists to Pakistan, has a maximum capacity of 200 people. It features a slide, climbing walls and various castle-themed decorations.

(AP)

Indians queue for Israel jobs as war in Gaza rages

AFP
Lucknow (India), Jan. 26

Indians queuing in long lines for jobs in Israel as the war with Hamas grinds on say the risks to their safety are preferable to unemployment at home.

Recruiters are aiming to fill a labour shortage in Israel exacerbated by nearly four months of fighting against Palestinian militants in Gaza.

While India is the world's fifth-largest economy and one of the fastest growing, it has struggled to produce enough full-time and well-paying jobs for millions of people.

For the hundreds of Indians in line, almost all men, the chance of a skilled construction job in Israel -- and wages up to 18 times higher -- outweighs their fears.

"If it is written in our fate to die, we'll die there -- at least our kids will get something," said motorbike mechanic Jabbar Singh, among the packed crowd at a training centre and recruitment site in Lucknow, the capital of Uttar Pradesh state. "It's better than hunger here."

India's urban unemployment rate -- the percentage of people wanting work who cannot find a job -- dipped to 5.1 percent in July 2022-June 2023, from 6.6 percent between the same months a year earlier.



PHOTO: AFP

Indians queuing for jobs aimed at plugging wartime employment gaps in Israel.

Over the same period, nearly 22 percent of India's workforce was classified as "casual labour", with average monthly wages a paltry 7,899 rupees ($95), according to government figures.

Indian tile designer Deepak Kumar said it was a matter of "work for four days, eat for two days".

Kumar said he followed the news and knew the risks, but wanted to find work for the sake of his children.

"I will smile and take a bullet -- but will take 150,000 rupees ($1,800)", he said.

'10,000 families will be fed'

Indians working in Israel is a well-trodden path.

The Indian embassy in Tel Aviv says there are about 18,000 Indian citizens in Israel, "primarily caregivers" looking after the elderly, as well as others employed as diamond traders and IT professionals. Some are students.

But recruiters have launched a fresh drive for job seekers.

Raj Kumar Yadav, head of Lucknow's Industrial Training Institute, said they were facilitating recruiters from Israel looking for 10,000 skilled construction workers who could earn as much as $1,685 a month.

"They will give them the visa and take the people with them on a chartered plane", he said, adding that "10,000 families will be fed well and will grow".

The programme is supported by the authorities in both nations, he said.

India's foreign ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told reporters last week there were long-existing employment agreements between the countries.

"We already have a large number of people, especially in the caregiving sector in Israel," Jaiswal said, adding that the agreement helped to ensure "regulated migration".

As the men queued in Lucknow, about 4,500 kilometres (2,800 miles) away, Israel stepped up its assault in the Gazan city of Khan Yunis, with the Palestinian Islamist movement Hamas saying dozens were killed in heavy bombardments and urban combat.

The war erupted on October 7 when Hamas and other militants from Gaza launched an unprecedented attack on Israel that resulted in about 1,140 deaths, according to an AFP tally of official Israeli figures.

Militants also seized 250 hostages, and Israel says around 132 remain in Gaza. That number includes the bodies of at least 28 dead hostages, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Israel in response has vowed to crush Hamas, and launched a relentless military offensive that the Palestinian territory's health ministry says has killed at least 25,900 people, about 70 percent of them women and children.

Thai and Nepali farm workers were among those killed and taken hostage in the Hamas attack. Some of the hostages have been released.

That provoked fear among foreign workers, many of whom fled after the attack, stripping the farm sector of a key source of labour.

Israel has also withdrawn 130,000 work permits from Palestinians in the occupied West Bank.

Indian workers provide one way to fill the gap.

Father of two Keshav Das said he felt he had no choice.

"There is no work here, so I will have to work somewhere," Das told AFP. "I know I am going in the red zone. But I have to feed my family, so I will have to go out. Otherwise, my kids will die hungry."

TODAY IN HISTORY

1785 – The University of Georgia is founded, the first public university in the United States.
1825 – The U.S. Congress approves Indian Territory (in what is present-day Oklahoma), clearing the way for forced relocation of the Eastern Indians on the "Trail of Tears".
1880 – Thomas Edison receives a patent for his incandescent lamp.
1916 – World War I: The British government passes the Military Service Act that introduces conscription in the United Kingdom.
1918 – Beginning of the Finnish Civil War.
1939 – First flight of the Lockheed P-38 Lightning.
1967 – Cold War: The Soviet Union, the United States, and the United Kingdom sign the Outer Space Treaty in Washington, D.C., banning deployment of nuclear weapons in space, and limiting the usage of the Moon and other celestial bodies to peaceful purposes.
2013 – Two hundred and forty-two people die in a nightclub fire in the Brazilian city of Santa Maria, Rio Grande do Sul.

BHERI MUNICIPALITY CONDUCTS FREE HEALTH CAMPS

BY BASHUDEV SHARMA
Jajarkot, Jan. 26

Bheri Municipality has conducted free health camps at three health institutions. The municipality operated free camps for cervical cancer at the Bohara Basic Health Centre, Jagatipur Health Post and Kudu Health Post.

As per the health branch of the municipality, the camps were aimed at informing women left homeless by the November 3 earthquake about cervical cancer. A total of 120 women benefitted from the camps, it said.

Khim Pun, head of the branch, said that the camps were also designed to treat women suffering from complicated diseases after the quake. He also hoped they wished to serve women from remote areas and weak financial backgrounds.

Maimi Khatri of Bheri Municipality-13, who has been visiting hospitals in Nepalgunj and Surkhet for the past five years to treat cervical issues, urged the authorities to conduct regular camps to serve needy women at their doorsteps.

"I have had to sell land to get medicine," she described the situation. "It would be wonderful if the local government offers these kinds of free services to women, children, new mothers and senior citizens."

INDIAN EMBASSY HOSTS REPUBLIC DAY FUNCTION IN CAPITAL

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The 75th Republic Day of India was celebrated at the Embassy of India in Kathmandu on Friday. The celebrations began with the unfurling of India's national flag by Ambassador of India to Nepal Naveen Srivastava.

The ambassador also conveyed his greetings on the occasion to the members of the Indian Diaspora in Nepal.

This was followed by a video of the address to the nation from the President of India, Droupadi Murmu. In her message, the President highlighted India's achievements in various fields since the last Independence Day, particularly the successful G20 Summit under India's Presidency and the Chandrayaan-3 Mission.

During the celebrations, the Ambassador felicitated widows and next of kin of deceased soldiers by disbursing their dues of NR. 50.4 million and blankets.

Reiterating its commitment to helping the retired soldiers, the Embassy unveiled the Bhu Puu-2024 magazine covering the welfare initiatives of the Government of India for ex-servicemen domiciled in Nepal.

The ambassador also presented books worth Rs. 1.9 million to various 30 institutions, according to a statement issued by the Embassy of India.

Later in the afternoon, Ambassador Srivastava hosted a reception at India House.

Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Speaker Devraj Ghimire, Deputy Prime Ministers Purna Bahadur Khadka and Narayankaji Shrestha, Nepali Congress president Sher Bahadur Deuba, CPN (Unified Socialist) chairman Madhav Kumar Nepal, former Prime Minister Dr. Baburam Bhattarai, former chairman of the Council of Minister Khil Raj Regmi, former Speaker Agni Prasad Sapkota, sitting Cabinet ministers, formers ministers, lawmakers, politicians, business community leaders and others attended the reception.

On the occasion, welcoming the guests, Ambassador Srivastava, shed light on the importance of Republic Day and Nepal-India relations and cooperation.

PM stresses...

Prime Minister Prachanda also reminded that Nepal, the birthplace of Lord Buddha, has been playing a significant role in various international fora for the establishment of peace in the world. He also pledged Nepal's support for all United Nations initiatives aimed at building harmony.

"The work done by the United Nations for peace and disarmament is commendable," he said, adding, "We support all initiatives to this regard and promise to stand with the organisation in future as well."

On the occasion, Nakamitsu noted that the UN Regional Centre for Peace and Disarmament in Asia and the Pacific was located in Nepal and hoped that the country would become the centre for peace in the South Asian region. " "The centre was established with the expectation that Nepal would be a centre for peace between nuclear-armed neighbours," she said.

Nakamitsu also praised Nepal as the second-largest contributor to the United Nations' peacekeeping mission.



PHOTO: RSS

An elderly potter making earthenware in Bhaktapur.

Helambu receives heavy snowfall

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Various mountainous districts in the country have witnessed snowfall for the past few days.

Districts like Sindhupalchowk, Dolakha, and several other highland areas in the Koshi, Bagmati, Gandaki, and Karnali regions received light to heavy snowfall.

According to our correspondent in Sindhupalchowk, Helambu Rural Municipality of Sindhupalchowk district experienced heavy snowfall on Friday.

Nima Gyalzen Sherpa, Chairman of Helambu Rural Municipality, said that domestic tourists have begun arriving to play in the snow after heavy snowfall began in Helambu's Great Tail and Himsikhar areas.

Due to the snowfall, the temperature in the Helambu region has plummeted to minus 20 degrees Celsius. The cold spell shows no signs of abating, making daily life increasingly challenging for residents.

With the intensifying cold, locals have voiced difficulties in coping. As a result of the snowfall, schools in high mountain areas have remained closed for several days.

The frigid conditions are particularly impacting vulnerable groups such as children, senior citizens, patients, and pregnant women.

Similarly, our Dolakha correspondent reported snowfall for the second time in Kalinchowk, a religious and tourist destination in Dolakha.

Kalinchowk experienced heavy snowfall last night. This marks the second snowfall of the year in Kalinchowk, with snow also blanketing the northern Himalayas of the district.

Following the snowfall, the Kalinchowk and Shailung areas have been transformed into a pristine white landscape. Domestic tourists have flocked the region to enjoy the snow, particularly in Kalinchowk, situated at an altitude of 3,842 meters.

Similarly, heavy snowfall has been reported in the upper reaches of Shailung Danda. The farmers in Shailung are delighted by the snow, as snow and rain are conducive to thriving potato cultivation.

Yam Pakhrin, the proprietor of Highland Hotel, expressed that hoteliers in Kuri are delighted by the influx of visitors. Tourists from Kathmandu, the Tarai region, and even Indian citizens have journeyed to the Kalinchowk region to witness the snowfall, bringing joy to the local hotel industry.

According to him, all the hotels in Kuri have been fully booked since a week. This marks the first time this year that hotels are operating at full capacity. Bookings are still being made for the upcoming days. Additionally, with the commencement of snowfall, the cable car in Kalinchowk has also resumed full operation.

Maoist Centre changes PP leader in Sudurpashchim

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhangadhi, Jan. 26

The CPN (Maoist Centre) has changed the leader of their parliamentary party in the Sudurpashchim Province Assembly.

Provincial leaders had earlier travelled to Kathmandu and met with party Chairman and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Vice Chairman and Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha to get the parliamentary party (PP) leader changed.

Building on these meetings, the PP met under deputy leader Akkal Bahadur Rawal on Friday and voted to make Man Bahadur Dhami 'Santosh' their leader and remove Khaga Raj Bhatta from the position.

The Maoists have 10 members in the Provincial Assembly. Of them, six were present at the meeting. In addition to Rawal and Santosh, Om Bikram Bhat 'Saral', Laxmi BK, Shiva Singh Oli and Dita Devi Mal attended the meeting. Mal is also the province's State Minister for Industry, Tourism, Forests and Environment.

Former PP leader Bhatta, Jhapat Singh Rawal (provincial Minister for Social Development, Ramesh Singh Dhami (provincial Industry, Tourism, Forests and Environment) and Janaki Poudel Kunwar were not present in the meeting.

Responding to The Rising Nepal's questions about the leadership change, Bhatta said that he was not aware of the decision "made by friends who feel they are in the majority." He said there would be discussions with his party's central and provincial leaders as well as PP leaders who did not attend the meeting regarding the validity of the process. He also said that his "friends" did not heed the request made by the party's top brass to maintain the status quo for now.

But Rawal said that the leadership change took place on the advice of central leaders. "We had delayed the process due to the National Assembly election," he said. "Now, we are discussing the possibility of changing ministers as well."

Currently, the Maoists have two ministers and one state minister in the provincial government.

Rawal informed that they had informed the Provincial Assembly Secretariat about the election of the new PP leader too.

Australians protest British colonisation on a national holiday

AP
Sydney, Jan. 26

Thousands of Australians protested the anniversary of British colonization of their country with large crowds Friday urging for Australia Day to be moved and for a day of mourning on the holiday some call "Invasion Day."

The holiday marks the arrival of 11 British ships carrying convicts at Port Jackson in present-day Sydney on Jan. 26, 1788. For many activists, the day marked the beginning of a sustained period of discrimination and expulsion of Indigenous people from their land without a treaty.

Thousands of people, many of whom waved Indigenous flags, rallied in front of the Victoria state parliament in Melbourne, calling for an official day of mourning to be declared across Australia. Roads and tram lines were shut down for more than four hours.

Large crowds in Sydney chanted for the Australia Day date to be moved. Thousands of protesters also rallied in Brisbane, and the second day of Australia's cricket match against the West Indies was briefly disrupted by demonstrators.



PHOTO AP

People attend an Indigenous Australians protest during Australia Day in Sydney, Friday, Jan. 26.

Major sports have stopped calling the holiday Australia Day, and the Australian Football League Players Association, several clubs and hockey teams have called for the date to change.

On Thursday, two monuments symbolizing Australia's colonial past were damaged in Melbourne. A statue of British naval officer James Cook, who in 1770 charted Sydney's coast, was sawn off at the ankles, and a Queen Victoria monument was doused in red paint.

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people represented 3.8% of Australia's population of 26 million, according to a Bureau of Statistics census in 2021. Indigenous people are the nation's most disadvantaged ethnic minority.

Preparations intensify for April investment summit

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The Office of the Investment Board, Nepal (OIBN), the national investment promotion and Public-Private Partnership (PPP) agency of Nepal, has speeded up the final preparations for the upcoming Investment Summit 2024.

To update the stakeholders about the initial preparations the Board along with collaborative partner KPMG in India, organised a workshop on 'Unlocking Nepal's Investment Potential: Collaborative Strategies for Economic Growth, in Kathmandu on Friday. The workshop was held as the pre-event of the Nepal Investment Summit (NIS) 2024 that is proposed to be held on April 28-29 this year.

The workshop delved into enhancing the investment climate in Nepal through legal, procedural and regulatory reforms as well as the innovative approaches to facilitate private investments including Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) to unleash the country's full potential among the policymakers, private sector, development partners and experts.

Addressing the workshop, Finance Minister and the Vice-Chairperson of IBN, Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, said that the country was pursuing fresh investments in every sector of the economy as the country's potential are largely untapped and under-utilised.

"As green investment has become a buzzword in recent days, there are not any better investment destinations except Nepal as we emit insignificant and carry potential to serve clean and renewable energy to other countries of the region to minimise emissions in line with their targets," he said.

Dr. Mahat further said, "Similar potentials are long awaiting to be unlocked in the sector of tourism, agri-business and ICT."

Stating that there is no ceiling for foreign investment in Nepal, he urged the investors, both national and foreign, to tap into the current policies that priorities Foreign Direct Investment and joint venture initiatives.

Vice-Chairperson of the National Planning Commission, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, highlighted that private investments are crucial for the sustainable and inclusive growth trajectory for the irreversible graduation of Nepal to the league of developing countries by 2026.

Likewise, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal, Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, underlined the prompt response based on the feedback of the foreign investors investing in Nepal as well as the private sector is crucial to spreading the message among the potential investors that their investments in Nepal won't be a loss.

Chief Executive Officer of the IBN, Sushil Bhatta, highlighted that NIS 2024 will provide a platform to onboard serious, potential and capable investors in our investment landscape.

"With its serious efforts, the government has been reviewing the various policies and laws to provide a favourable and better investment climate for unleashing Nepal's full potential in various sectors including the development of strategic infrastructure in different sectors clean transport, road, tourism, ICT, manufacturing and mining among others," he said.

Similarly, Acting Governor of the Nepal Rastra Bank, Dr. Neelam Dhungana Timsina, shared information regarding the provisions of recently amended FDI and Foreign Loan Bylaws, which removed the provisions of pre-approval of the central bank to bring in FDI.

Yezdi Nagporewalla, CEO of KPMG in India, underscored that the success of this joint effort between IBN and KPMG delivered a commitment to fostering strategic partnerships and driving sustainable growth for Nepal.

Meanwhile, Minister for Foreign Affairs, NP Saud, said that Nepal should do its homework for the upcoming Investment Summit. Addressing the 'Award for Excellence' programme held on Friday in Kathmandu, he pointed out the need to create an investment-friendly environment and said that more homework is needed.

Minister Saud also said that he was also working to speed up economic diplomacy. He added, "Economic diplomacy is important for the success of the conference and we are working for this."

According to him, it is also necessary to explain the reforms in the investment policy to create an investment-friendly environment to attract foreigners.

Minister Saud said that the investors should be assured that the investment made in Nepal could be profitable, and beneficial and that the profits could be reinvested or safely repatriated back to their country.

The upcoming investment summit will be the third one in the recent series of conferences organised to attract foreign investment in large projects. Earlier, investment conferences were held in 2017 and 2019.

Reconstruction of subsided Kamala bridge begins

BY BIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 26

The reconstruction of the subsided bridge across the Kamala River that connects Dhanusha and Siraha districts under the Postal Highway has started.

The construction company has begun its reconstruction process from January 16 and the work has moved ahead in full swing from Friday.

According to the construction company, the reconstruction is going on with the target to bring the bridge into operation before July this year.

An agreement has been signed between the Postal Highway Directorate Planning Office in Janakpur and bridge construction company Lumbini Builders to operate the bridge before July.

Krishan Kumar Mahato, Chief of the Postal Highway Directorate Project Office, said that the reconstruction works of the subsided bridge have been moving in full swing as per the agreement.

Construction of the bridge will be completed within the deadline, he added.

"The construction work got delayed as the amount to be received from insurance got stopped, Thapa said, adding, "Now I believe that reconstruction works will move in speed."

The bridge project was awarded to Pappu Constructions in June 2011.

More than 95 per cent of the work was completed after nearly 10 years of repeated extensions. The bridge subsided during floods in July and October of 2021 when preparations were underway for the inauguration of the bridge.

The construction agreement was revoked from Pappu Construction Company after its negligence led to the delay of the work, and the responsibility to complete the remaining works was handed over to Lumbin Builders.

The then Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Narayan Kaji Shrestha had directed the construction company to start the reconstruction work of the bridge within a week after inspecting the site along with a technical team on March 29 last year.

Israel vows to fight Hamas all the way to Gaza's southern border

AP
Cairo, Jan. 26

Israel faces a growing risk of damaging its peace with neighboring Egypt as its military pushes the offensive against Hamas further south in the Gaza Strip. Already, the two sides are in a dispute over a narrow strip of land between Egypt and Gaza.

Israeli leaders say that to complete their destruction of Hamas, they must eventually widen their offensive to Gaza's southernmost town, Rafah, and take control of the Philadelphi Corridor, a tiny buffer zone on the border with Egypt that is demilitarized under the two countries' 1979 peace accord.

In a news conference last week, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Hamas continues to smuggle weapons under the border – a claim Egypt vehemently denies — and that the war cannot end "until we close this breach," referring to the corridor.

That brought a sharp warning from Egypt that deploying Israeli troops in the zone, known in Egypt as the Salaheddin Corridor, will violate the peace deal.

"Any Israeli move in this direction will lead to a serious threat to Egyptian-Israeli relations," Diaa Rashwan, head of Egypt's State Information Service, said Monday.

'Gurkha Warrior' to be screened from Feb 23



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Historical film 'Gurkha Warrior,' is set to hit local theatres on February 23.

Trailer of the Nepali version of the film was released amid a programme held at Bishwojyoti Cineplex in Kathmandu on Thursday and simultaneously released on the OSR Digital YouTube channel.

Directed by Milan Chams, the 2-minute and 22-second trailer delves into the struggles and hardships faced by Gurkha soldiers during the Malayan War.

The film primarily focuses on the Gorkhali forces' involvement in the Malayan War during World War II, highlighting the difficulties they encountered during that tumultuous time.

During the event, director Chams said, "There are numerous untold stories of the battles fought by the Gorkhali soldiers in the First and Second World Wars. As these stories are gradually fading away, we have chosen to portray the narrative of the Malayan War in this movie."

Actor Ritesh Chams, making his debut in the film, shared that after about eight years of preparation, he entered the role of an actor.

Given his background as a Gurkha soldier, he found it somewhat easier to authentically portray the character of a Gorkhali soldier in the film.

Even before its official release, 'Gurkha Warrior' has gained immense popularity, having had a historic red carpet premiere in the UK.

The film has garnered international attention, especially after being nominated for a British Academy of Film and Television Arts (BAFTA) award.

The film is multilingual, being produced in Nepali, Hindi, English, and Korean languages. While the Nepali version is ready for release, the production of the Hindi, Korean, and English versions is in its final stage, informed in the programme.

Along with Ritesh Chams, Vijay Lama, Rebika Gurung, Shishir Wangdel, Kabita Ale, Birup Ghale and Sara Rai have done the film.

The film is co-written by director Milan Chams and Giriraj Ghimire. Rabindra Neupane and Babu Shreshta are the cinematographers Milan Shrestha editor of the film.

The Hindi version features a song sung by Indian singer Saan.

Presented by London Cine Eye Production & Chams Entertainment, the film is produced by Suman Rai and Sushmita Waiba, with Prashant Thapa and Rajendra Ghimire as executive producers.

Mandala Theatre stages Masinya

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26



A special performance of the play 'Masinya' was staged at Mandala Theatre in Thapagaun on Wednesday.

Distinguished figures from the realms of literature, art, music, politics and communication watched the play.

The theatrical production vividly depicts the struggles faced by the Tamang community, providing a glimpse into their lifestyle, culture, rhythm, and surroundings.

After watching the play, Rajendra Mahato, a senior leader of the Loktantrik Samajwadi Party, expressed that the play was not merely a theatrical presentation, it embodied the pains experienced by the community.

Mahato urged the younger generation to comprehend this pain and emphasised the need to combat such injustices.

He insisted that the play should be showcased nationwide to advocate for the recognition of the community's rights, highlighting what he perceives as state-sponsored discrimination against the Tamang community through the label 'Masinya.'

The potency of drama in raising public awareness was stressed by Janajati leader Ang Kaji Sherpa. He urged the artists to stage the play within the Tamang community and among indigenous Nepalis living around the world.

Mohan Gole, Member Secretary of Tamsaling Sangharsh Committee and chairperson of Nepal Tamang Ghedung, announced plans to take the play to all seven provinces as part of an awareness campaign.

Written by Raju Syangtan, Laxmi Rumba, and Rabat, the play is conceptualised and directed by Buddhi Tamang and Sonam Lama.

The staging will continue from Thursday to February 11. Rupesh Tamang, Rohni Lama, Sunil Tamang, Bishnu Moktan, Ramila Moktan, Rabin Dong, Bikas Lama, Sheetal Thokar, Bijay Nepal and Nirmal Saud among others are acting.

Rejina makes a comeback in silver screen after 11 years



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The cast lineup for the film 'Modibeni,' which is currently in preparation for shooting, has been finalised. Amar Pratap Shrestha is set to make his debut in film from this project. Currently, the unit is conducting an acting workshop.

Shrestha, known for his roles in two plays at Ojas Theatre, has also appeared in advertisements and a web-series titled 'Preetko Reet.'

Making a comeback after 11 years, actress Rejina Upreti, whose last film 'Baradan' was released in 2013, will be part of the cast. Rejina has an extensive background, having served as vice president and senior vice president in the artist association for two terms.

During this period, she continued to engage in acting through music videos, commercials, and short films.

In 'Modibeni,' Rejina will share the screen with actor Dilip KC.

Furthermore, seasoned actor Saroj Khanal will also play a role in the film, alongside Kamalmani Nepal, Jeevan Bhattarai, Saroj Aryal, Anamika Lamichhane, Sneh Bhattarai, and others who were selected through auditions.

The film is directed by Shankar Koirala and produced by Dinest Entertainment, with Dilip KC serving as the producer and Hari Shrestha as the co-producer. The screenplay is written by Anand Bikram Chhetri. The storyline is set in the Modibeni area of Parbat district, encompassing a blend of events from 35-40 years ago to the present day. The shooting of the film is scheduled to commence on January 30.

HERBERT COWARD DIES IN NORTH CAROLINA HIGHWAY CRASH

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 26

Herbert Coward, known for his "Toothless Man" role in the movie "Deliverance," died Wednesday in a crash on a western North Carolina highway, according to authorities. He was 85.

The crash happened Wednesday afternoon as Coward and Bertha Brooks, 78, left a doctor's appointment, North Carolina Highway Patrol Sgt. M.J. Owens said by telephone on Thursday. Coward pulled out onto U.S. Route 19 in front of a pickup truck, which hit his car, Owens said. Coward and Brooks as well as a Chihuahua and pet squirrel were killed, he said. Coward, who lived in Haywood County, was famous locally for having a pet squirrel, he said.

The 16-year-old driver of the truck was taken to a hospital as a precaution. Authorities don't believe speed or distraction were factors in the crash, Owens said. Coward had a small but memorable role in John Boorman's 1972 classic "Deliverance." The film starred Jon Voight, Burt Reynolds, Ned Beatty and Ronny Cox as a group of businessmen canoeing down a river in remote Georgia.

Man arrested outside Taylor Swift's NYC home held without bail for violating protective order

AP
New York, Jan. 26



A Seattle man who police say has been stalking and harassing Taylor Swift was ordered held without bail Thursday after he was arrested three times in recent days in front of the pop star's home in Manhattan's Tribeca neighborhood.

David Crowe, 33, was arraigned in Manhattan Criminal Court on a misdemeanor charge of second-degree criminal contempt, according to Manhattan District Attorney Alvin Bragg's office. He was also ordered to undergo a psychiatric exam. Prosecutors said Crowe violated a protective order issued Wednesday mandating he stay away from Swift and her home and refrain from any communication with her.

Crowe was arrested Wednesday by officers responding to complaints of an emotionally disturbed man acting erratically near Swift's townhouse. He was arraigned and issued the protection order, but a short time later he was arrested again near Swift's residence. Court documents say an unidentified security worker had spotted Crowe near the singer's home about 30 times since Nov. 25. Crowe was asked about 10 times not to approach the building or to leave, according to prosecutors.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Your reflection could be practically begging for you to flex and show off. Maybe you recently made a large purchase or got a raise that inflated your ego. Wanting to share this with other people is understandable.

CANCER: A group of people may extend their hand to you, but you might turn it away if you're not careful. Shyness or exhaustion could have you avoiding large gatherings or spontaneous events.

LIBRA: Times have changed, Libra! Even as others struggle with their egos, you may be grappling with an unhealthy lack of ego. Working to assist a person who isn't doing their part is exhausting.

CAPRICORN: Ego could hamper your success. You might be recognized for your efforts at any moment -- perhaps you're seen as a solid figure in the community or at your workplace.

TAURUS: The world may seem to rest completely on your shoulders. True, it is technically possible that most of the work being done at your workplace is being done by you, or that you've contributed the bulk of a group project.

LEO: You have the power to take the lead. You may be worried that you wouldn't be a good leader, so you might shy away from leadership opportunities or avoid taking control of situations that you would be an ideal authority on.

SCORPIO: A recent opportunity might not resonate with your soul. While it may sound generally good on paper or offer specific benefits that you would like to receive, be on the lookout for anything about the offer that gives you pause.

AQUARIUS: Your family can help you to get ahead -- if you let them. Whether they're family by blood, marriage, or choice, they probably want to offer you their assistance in whatever ways you allow.

GEMINI: Lady Luck is beckoning! Unfortunately, you might have other plans -- when an important window opens for you, you could be tempted to reject it in favor of your original plans.

VIRGO: Attempts to chase your dreams might be stymied by a lack of consistency. No matter how passionate you are about your goals, solely dreaming about them won't be as useful as creating concrete routines.

SAGITTARIUS: You're able to gain a support system. It could have been difficult for you to be consistent with certain things in the past, as you may have not had guidance or assistance when things got rough.

PISCES: You might feel baffled about your recent connections. Other people could be acting in strange or confusing ways that incite worries about potentially doing something wrong.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





SUKRA DEFENDS SURYA NEPAL EASTERN OPEN CROWN



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Nepal No 1 pro Sukra Bahadur Rai defended the title of the Surya Nepal Eastern Open at the par-70 Dharan Golf Club on Friday.

Local pro Sukra carded 1-under 69 in the third round and posted the 54-hole total score of 3-under 207. He recorded a five-stroke victory over fellow Dharan pro Niraj Tamang to claim his 10th career title and equal with veteran pro Deepak Magar and former Nepal No 1 pro Deepak Acharya. Along with the title, Sukra received Rs 140,000.

Niraj finished second at 2-over 212 after he played 3-over 73 and he received Rs 96,000. Former top pro Bhuvan Nagarkoti played 1-over 71 to finish third at 3-over 213 and he got Rs 72,000. Rajen Rai, Bhuwan Kumar Rokka and Rame Magar shared the fourth position at 7-over 217. Rajen and Bhuwan played 73 each, while Rame shot 71. They earned Rs 50,500 each.

Gajendra Gurung won the amateur section title on countback after he was tied on 8-over 218 with Yubraj Bhujel. Gajendra played 3-over 73 on the final day, while Yubraj faltered to 6-over 76. Yubraj was five strokes ahead of Gajendra going into the final round but he faltered to 4-over 40 on the front nine and played 2-over 36 on the back nine. Gajendra played 1-over 37 and 2-over 36 on two halves respectively. Suman Pariyar (70) and Sundar Rai (75) were joint third at 11-over 221.

Against many odds, Nepal's youngsters progress to super six

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Nepali cricket fans had to wait for the 45th over to breathe a sigh of great relief as the under-19 men's cricket team progressed to the super six stage in the ICC U19 World Cup defeating Afghanistan in a hard-fought battle.



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN
Nepal's captain Dev Khanal reacts after scoring half century against Afghanistan during their last group match of ICC U19 World Cup Cricket in South Africa on Friday.

In a match filled with twists and turns, Nepal was able to win by one wicket chasing a low-target of 146.

Starting furiously with the ball after Afghanistan chose to bat first at Buffalo Park in East London, South Africa, on Friday, Aakash Chand became a nightmare for the opponent as he sent five of the top six batsmen back to the pavilion.

When Chand took his fifth wicket, Afghanistan was at 43/6 in 11.3 overs. Gulshan Jha took the other one, which was of wicket-keeper-batsman and opener of Afghanistan Numan Shah. It was thanks to a captain's inning by Naseer Khan Maroofkhil as he partnered with Allah Mohammad Ghazanfar and Faridoon Dawoodzai, who came in at eight and ten respectively, after entering the crease at the 10th over to take the team to a far-better total than that they expected after Chand's furiosity.

Dipesh Kandel took two wickets and the Bhandari-duo (Subash and Tilak) bagged one each as Afghanistan was bundled out in the first ball of the 41st over. Khan, Ghazanfar and Dawoodzai departed after scoring 31 off 83, 37 off 21 and 29 off 65 respectively.

The Rhino Army alongside the young team representing Nepal were pretty confident to chase the target with ease. Nevertheless, Afghanistan had not lost its determination as it was also looking for the win desperately.

Nepal and Afghanistan both lost their matches against New Zealand and Pakistan in Group D. Since only three of the top teams in a group of four could progress to super six, Nepal and Afghanistan players gave everything on the field. Moreover, Afghanistan was not afraid to defend the target which was numerically low as it was in a worse situation against a better team on January 23. Playing against the young Black Caps, Afghanistan was bundled out for 91. New Zealand chased the target, but it cost the team nine wickets.

Nepal also had to lose nine wickets against Afghanistan today. Losing three wickets in the first 10 overs – Arjun Kumal (10 off 14), Bipin Rawal (2 off 19) and Gulshan Jha (1 off 12) – captain Dev Khanal partnered with Aakash Tripathi for the next 13 overs.

Tripathi departed at 23.1 overs contributing 16 off 39. While Khana stayed, two wickets fell before 30 overs. Deepak Dumre and Dipesh Kandel after adding 5 off 13 and 4 off 4 respectively.

As the wickets were falling continuously, Nepal was in the chase until Khanal was at the crease. He was able to register a half-century, but got caught behind the stumps with a soft edge in the 37th over. With seven fours, Khanal faced 89 deliveries to score 58 runs.

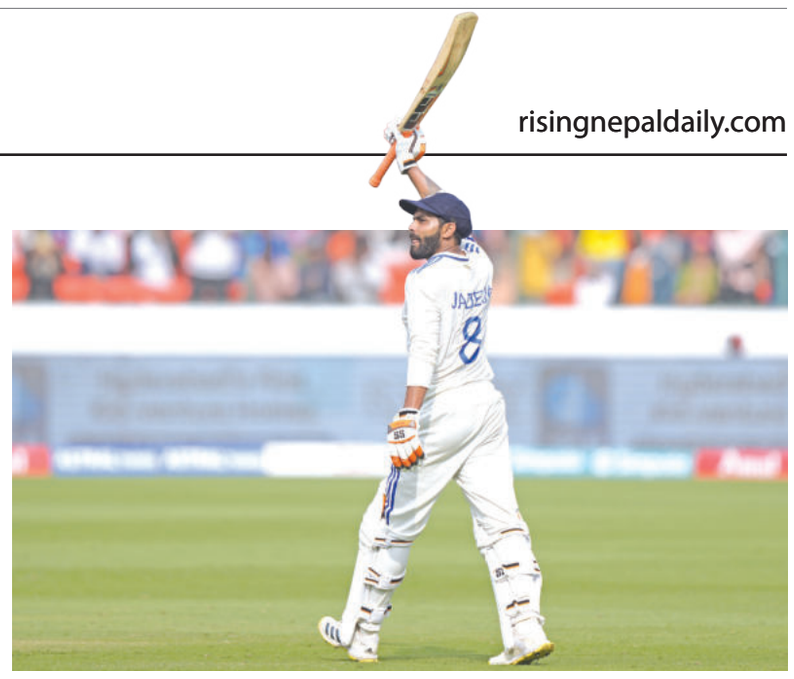
Khanal's departure was a shock for Nepal while a hope for Afghanistan. The hope went higher for Afghanistan as danger-looking Dipak Bohora 27 off 42), who came in at eight, and 10th-wicket-batsman Aakash Chand, got bowled by Dawoodzai in the 42nd and 44th overs.

With the Bhandari-duo on the crease for a final-wicket-partnership once again after showing a good batting inning against the Black Caps earlier, Nepal still had a chance. As Nepal had no wicket to spare, every person in the Afghanistan team surrounded Subash inside the 30-yard circle.

Yet, it was not enough for Afghanistan as Subash got the winning runs and won the match against one of the three test-playing nations in Group D. Subash scored nine runs facing 29 deliveries while Tilak did not have to face any ball; meanwhile, Tilak ran for the winning runs.

Chand was adjudged as the player of the match for his five-wicket-haul.

Nepal, alongside New Zealand and Pakistan, will progress to face the top three teams from Group A (India, Bangladesh, Ireland, USA) in the super six.



Jadeja helps India take 175-run lead

AP
Hyderabad, Jan. 26

Ravindra Jadeja hit his 20th test half-century as India took a commanding 175-run lead against England on the second day of the first test.

Jadeja scored 81 not out as India finished on 421-7 at stumps after resuming Friday on 119-1. England scored 246 runs in its first innings.

Jadeja was India's third batter to score 50-plus runs in the first innings, after Lokesh Rahul was out caught for 86 and opener Yashasvi Jaiswal got 80.

After lunch, India was still trailing by 24 runs and Rahul came out firing. Shreyas Iyer was caught at midwicket off Rehan Ahmed but the dismissal didn't bother Rahul, who hit another four fours and two sixes, shifting up the gears as he approached a century. But he perished while attacking, caught at midwicket off Tom Hartley.

India was in the lead by then as Rahul had added another 65 runs with Jadeja. Jadeja anchored India's innings in the final two sessions.

First, he added 68 runs with Srikar Bharat, who fought his way to 41 runs. The keeper-batter had a tough time against Joe Root's off spin, but settled down to face 81 balls in all. India went to tea at 309-5.

Root did get reward for his hard work in the final session, finishing the day with 2-77 in 24 overs. He had earlier dismissed Jaiswal in the first over Friday.

Jadeja reached his half-century off 84 balls, and his swordplay celebrations delighted the holiday crowd in Hyderabad.

Axar Patel (35 not out) joined Jadeja in the middle, and the duo stayed together until stumps, adding 63 runs.

Australia fights back

Blistering half centuries by Alex Carey and captain Pat Cummins led Australia's fightback on Day 2 of the day-night test against West Indies on Friday.

Carey smashed 65 runs off 49 balls and Cummins finished unbeaten on 64 off 73 before he declared Australia's first innings at 289-9 despite still trailing by 22. The decision to give his fast bowlers a chance to bowl with the pink ball under lights for half an hour paid off.

West Indies reached 13-1 in its second innings at stumps for an overall lead of 35 runs.

Usman Khawaja, who was named ICC test player of the year 2023 on Friday, once again played a meaningful knock of 75, after West Indies' first innings effort of 311.

Carey provided the bulk of the scoring with his aggressive shots as he raised a 96-run partnership with Khawaja after West Indies fast bowlers Kemar Roach (3-47) and Alzarri Joseph (4-84) had reduced Australia to 54-5 soon after the first session.

SNIPPETS

Santoshi wins Dhaka Marathon Gold

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal's Santoshi Shrestha won the gold in the Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujib Dhaka Marathon 2024 held in Dhaka, Bangladesh on Friday. Santoshi, the gold winner of the 13th South Asian Games (SAG) held in Nepal, completed the distance of 42.195 km in 2 hours 46 minutes and 22 seconds. In the same event, Pushpa Bhandari won the silver by completing the distance in 2 hours 49 minutes and 34 seconds. In the men's section, Khadak Bahadur Khadka was third. He completed the distance in 2 hours 18 minutes and 32 seconds. A total of seven athletes participated from Nepal.

NRT, Birtamod vying for Ilam Gold Cup

Kathmandu (TRN): Kathmandu's New Road Team (NRT) is competing against Birtamod United FC in the finals of the 1st NRNA Ilam Gold Cup on Saturday. While NRT had defeated Red Horse FC, the tournament's host, in the semi-finals, Birtamod booked its place in the finals by defeating Panchthar Football Club. NRT had defeated Red Horse FC in sudden death after the match ended 3-3 in a tie-breaker. On the other hand, from a goalless 90 minutes, Birtamod defeated Panchthar 4-2 in extra time. The winner of the tournament will receive a cash prize of Rs. 500,000 and the runner-up will receive Rs. 300,000.

Police into Qarter-finals

Kathmandu (TRN): Nepal Police Club advanced to the quarter-finals of the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup defeating Armed Police Force (APF) Club 2-0 on Friday. Man Bahadur Pariyar scored the first goal for Nepal Police in the 19th minute. Furthermore, He extended the lead to 2-0 in the 71st minute and raised the bars for APF. APF could not reply with a goal despite creating some chances. Nepal Police will now face Church Boys United FC on January 30 after advancing in the knockout format of the tournament.

Atletico sails into Copa semis

Madrid (AFP) – Memphis Depay fired Atletico Madrid into the Copa del Rey semi-finals by earning his team a 1-0 win over Sevilla on Thursday. The Dutch forward, on as a substitute, prodded home in the final stages to help Atletico join Real Sociedad, Athletic Bilbao and Real Mallorca in the final four. Atletico survived a late scare when Pablo Barrios conceded a penalty but the decision was overturned after the referee reviewed the incident with VAR.

Nepal Police Club continues unbeaten run in PM Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

Defeating Karnali Province on Friday, Nepal Police Club now has six wins in six matches at the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament.

The only team to remain undefeated in the ongoing season, Nepal Police notched up six-wicket victory over Karnali.

Electing to bat first, Karnali's openers could only perform for the team. Captain Rabindra Shahi opened the innings and scored 40 off 35 before getting struck leg before. The other opener, Nischal Rawal, was able to reach the 50-run mark before getting run out in the 41st over after facing 107 deliveries. Only two other batsmen – Arjun Gharti (23 off 34) and Diwan Pun (20 off 5) – scored in double figures before the team was bundled out in the 43rd over for 171 runs.

Sagar Dhakal claimed three wickets, Lalit Bhandari took two and captain Dipendra Singh Airee, Lalit Rajbanshi and Kushal Bhurtel bagged one each for Nepal Police Club.

Kushal aggressively started the chase after opening with Dilip Nath. He scored 43 runs in only 28 deliveries with three maximums and three fours. He was bowled by Pun as the first wicket for Karnali in the 8th over.

Nath, on the other hand, was able to register a half-century as he stayed not out to help Nepal Police continue its undefeated run. He hit four sixes and six fours to chase the target successfully in the 24th over. Nath (75 off 62) stayed in the crease with Arjun Saud (2 off 3) as four wickets fell for the team.

Amit Shrestha only opened his account with a single while Airee was caught at 34 runs off 28 balls. Aarif Sheikh also added nine runs in seven balls for the team.

Prakash Jaishi took two wickets while Pun and Dipendra Rawat bagged one each for Karnali.

Nepal Police continues to top the table with 12 points in six matches. Bagmati, Madhes and Tribhuwan Army follow Nepal Police with 10, 10 and 8 points respectively. While Bagmati and Madhes have played eight matches each, Army has only played six.

Sinner ends 10-time champion Djokovic's Australian Open streak

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 26

Jannik Sinner ended one of Novak Djokovic's perfect streaks in an Australian Open upset and then got to relax while Daniil Medvedev rallied from two sets down to beat Alexander Zverev after midnight to secure the other place in the final.

For a self-described tennis fan, just everything went Sinner's way in the semi-finals Friday.

The 22-year-old Italian broke Djokovic's serve twice in each of the first two sets in a surprisingly lopsided 6-1, 6-2, 6-7 (6), 6-3 victory that ended the 10-time champion's unbeaten streak in semifinals at Rod Laver Arena.

Almost an hour after missing a match point in the tiebreaker, Sinner converted his second to complete his third win in four head-to-heads since losing to Djokovic in last year's Wimbledon semifinals.

"I learned a lot from that," he said of that Wimbledon loss and his subsequent wins. "It gives you a better feeling when you know that you can beat one player. "The confidence from the end of last year has for sure kept the belief."

Third-seeded Medvedev appeared down and out after two sets, and was two points from losing in the fourth, but rallied to beat Zverev 5-7, 3-6, 7-6 (4), 7-6 (5), 6-3 after 4 hours, 18 minutes.

"I was a little bit lost, but during the third set I started saying 'If I lose this match, I just want to be proud of myself,'" said Medvedev, who has lost two finals in Australia, including one from two sets up. "I'm proud of myself."

Sinner will be the youngest player to contest the men's final in Australia since Djokovic won the first of his 10 titles here in 2008. A record-extending 11th Australian and 25th major title overall will have to wait for Djokovic.



ANKA TO ORGANISE NEPAL KABADDI LEAGUE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 26

The All Nepal Kabaddi Association (ANKA) and Astrionix Event Management inked a contract in Kathmandu on Friday to organise a franchise-based Nepal Kabaddi League by 2024.

The league will be the first of its kind in Nepal. Nepal will be the second country in the world after India to organise such a league in kabaddi, the organisers informed. Arbind Kumar Jha, general-secretary at ANKA, informed that the two organisers will make public the number of teams participating in the league alongside other details in less than a month.

"We have planned to organise the league in July. However, since it is a commercial league requiring sponsors, the market conditions and other technicalities might affect it. Yet, we are working to make the league possible in 2024," said Amit Begani, CEO of Astrionix Event Management.

According to the organisers, E Prasad Rao, one of the flagbearers of kabaddi throughout the globe, has been agreed as the league's technical director.

"We plan to organise the league for the benefit of our local players. Nepal's women's team secured a medal in kabaddi at the 19th Asian Games. We have more to achieve in kabaddi," said Tulasi Thapa, chairperson of ANKA.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:53 am, Sunset at 5:40 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 15 - 17°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	14.5	2.1	0.0
Dipayal	22.2	1.9	0.0
Dhangadi	10.8	6.0	0.0
Birendranagar	20.7	2.6	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.3	8.8	0.0
Jumla	12.5	-5.2	0.0
Ghorahi	20.6	5.0	0.0
Pokhara	19.4	7.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	12.0	6.9	0.0
Simara	14.8	5.6	0.0
Kathmandu	17.5	3.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.3	4.8	0.0
Taplejung	14.0	3.0	0.5
Dhankuta	19.4	6.0	0.0
Biratnagar	17.2	7.8	0.0
Jomsom	6.0	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	21.5	8.2	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	3.7	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	7.4	0.0*
Jiri	12.8	-1.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 27, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.69	Rs. 133.29
Euro	1	Rs. 144.29	Rs. 144.94
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.09	Rs. 169.85
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.86	Rs. 154.56
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.58	Rs. 87.98
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.70	Rs. 99.15
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.07	Rs. 99.51
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.99	Rs. 9.03
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.50	Rs. 18.59
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.57
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.73	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.75	Rs. 12.81
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.35	Rs. 19.44
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.98	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.39	Rs. 433.34
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.99	Rs. 353.58

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54